UNIT 15

Tamil Nadu Political Thought

15.1 Historical Background

The 'Classical Tamil homeland (Tamizhagam) included today's Tamil Nadu besides some parts of Kerala, Andhra and Karnataka; **Strabo** (63 BC(BCE) to c. AD(CE) 24), a famous Greek geographer and historian observed the early diplomatic history of ancient Tamil Kingdom of Pandiyas. Naval expeditions of Cheras, Cholas, Pandiyas and Pallavas inform early maritime power and influence of Tamils. Ports in the coast of Tamil Nadu were important centres of trade between India and the Mediterranean, and India and southeast Asia, in the period. 200 BC(BCE) to 300 AD(CE). The ancient ports of *Korkai*, *Poompuhar*, *Vasavasamudram*, *Perimula*, *Arikamedu*, *Alagankulam*, *Mamallapuram* reveal the active trade, commerce and cultural exchanges with the Southeast Asian countries, Sri Lanka, China, Egypt, Greece and Rome. An established tradition of shipbuilding combined with rich maritime heritage of ancient Tamils are definite indicators of the foundations of influential polity, society, culture, trade and commercial ties with the outside world.

Sangam literature dated approximately 300 BC(BCE) to 300 AD(CE) is another valuable literary source(s) that reflects society, economy, culture and politics. The classification of Sangam poetry into **akam** (on love) and **puram** (on war, good and



Learning Objectives

The students will be able to

- Learn about ancient political ideas in Tamil Nadu.
- State clearly the political ideas of Thiruvalluvar.
- Understand about Nationalism through Bharathiyar
- Learn about communist ideas that existed in Tamilnadu through Singaravelar's writings on communism.
- Learn and understand Dravidian Ideology and its impact on the society, polity and economy in Tamil Nadu through the contributions of E.V.R.Periyar on social justice, equality and liberation from oppression of higher caste.
- Describe clearly the core meaning of Tamil Movement and Dravidian movement and its political discourse.

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